through which the Congress party connected with its cadre. However, this connection had been conspicuously absent during the years the party held power, as it shifted its focus to a ‘nirman’ (construction) mode, precluding the instigation of similar public movements. The Bharat Jodo Yatra rectified this deficiency by serving as the conduit through which the Congress worker re-established ties with the party, notably when its esteemed leader embarked on a mission traversing the streets of India.

Crystallizing the Hopes of Civil Society

One of the most remarkable aspects of the BJY was its ability to crystallize the hopes of civil society through deeply engaging interactions. My involvement in engaging with the civil society in Karnataka gave me a close-up view of this phenomenon. As the news of the Yatra was disseminated, it was the civil society leaders who recognized the transformative potential of the Yatra. Drawing from their extensive experience in advocating for the most marginalized, civil society comprehended that a language of humility was the sole conduit through which resonance with the broader populace could be achieved.

The civil society in Karnataka had consistently been at the forefront of significant struggles, such as the abrogation of Article 370 and the National Register of Citizens (NRC)/Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA) protests. Notably, they had successfully united under a common federal platform during the NRC/CAA struggle, owing to the concerted efforts of key leaders and organizations. Karnataka had evolved into a focal point for various protests against the prevailing authorities.

Amid the lockdown and the Covid-19 pandemic, civil society groups collaborated to evaluate deficiencies in their protest methods. During this period, they decided to forge closer alliances with several organizations in Karnataka, amalgamating into a singular entity named ‘Eddelu Karnataka’, or Wake Up Karnataka. Recognizing the efficacy of collective resistance